pious man, who will resolve the distractions of my heart.'

A king's duty was God's will, after all; or, as Akbar put it, 'Divine worship in monarchs consists in their justice and good administration.' But with such a multiplicity of gods in his realm, how was a ruler to know he wasn't in thrall to the Devil by mistake?

Akbar returned from Bengal and became as obsessed with prayer as he had been with conquest. Badauni describes him sitting alone on 'a large flat stone of an old building' near his palace, his head bent to his chest, absorbed in contemplation. Sometimes, he spent 'whole nights in praising God . . . pronouncing Ya huwa and Ya hadi . . . full of reverence for Him, who is the true Giver'.

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While Akbar sought after Truth, what of his subjects? It is hard to get a proper sense of religious feeling across the many diverse societies that comprised Akbar's growing empire; what impact religion had, great or little, on people's everyday lives. It is equally hard, however, to escape the sense that religion – whether as ritual or as a way of imagining a just world – was a quotidian and compelling force.

It was during the sixteenth century, for example, that Tulsidas wrote the Ramcharitmanas and Guru Arjan Dev compiled the Adi Granth[11] – some indication of the sheer variety of ideas, religious and social, that were in ferment, even in competition, at the time. These two monumental texts both offered ideas and ideals of truth and justice that would not have agreed with each other in every point. Thus, for example, B.B. Majumdar describes how Tulsidas 'states with evident regret that the Sudras now impart knowledge to the Brahmanas, take the sacred thread and accept reprehensible gifts . . . This was certainly a fling at the popularity of Ravidas the shoe-maker, Dharna the Jat, Sena the barber and other religious leaders belonging to non-Brahmana castes', some of whom were prominent Bhakti saints.[12] Sikhism, on the other hand, the tenets of which Guru Arjan Dev first compiled in the Adi Granth, was influenced by the Bhakti movement; indeed, the Adi Granth contains verses by several Bhakti saints. Evidently, this evolving faith ruffled some feathers; complaints about the Adi Granth seem to have reached Akbar, at which Guru Arjan Dev sent him the book.